MANAGING UNIQUE RELATIONSHIPS

Facilitator's Guide

DESCRIPTION	Utilize this facilitator's guide for: • Managing Unique Relationships Video • The Keys to Managing Up Resource Sheet • Eight Best Practices for Leading Friends Resource Sheet
OBJECTIVES	Participants should be able to: • Identify the challenges when leading unique relationships in a work setting. • Analyze the keys to building relationships and managing more senior leaders in the organization. • Understand how the best practices for leading friends can positively impact both personal relationships and professional contexts. • Utilize role play and boundary/balance mapping to develop more effective leadership practices when leading unique relationships.
Time for Facilitation	Between 20 - 120 minutes

Introduction

Brief Starting Intro:

Leaders face unique challenges when managing up and leading friends in the workplace. Managing up requires a careful balance of communicating effectively with superiors, advocating for the team's needs, and aligning with the broader organizational vision. Training helps leaders develop the confidence and skills to manage their superiors' expectations while fostering positive working relationships. Leading friends adds another layer of complexity, as it blurs personal and professional boundaries. Training on best practices equips leaders with strategies for maintaining objectivity, ensuring fairness, and avoiding favoritism, while still preserving strong personal bonds. These topics are critical to the development of a well-rounded leader who can successfully manage diverse professional relationships.

Pre-Facilitation: Check with participants to see if they watched the video and read the resource articles. They should have both watched and read the resources prior to asking the following questions.

Best Practice Facilitation: Place participants into pairs of two so that they can share first with the other participant before sharing their answer with the whole group. This "pair and share" technique allows individuals to test out their answer(s) with someone else first (instilling confidence in the answer) and helps to start building stronger relationships with others in the program.

Depending on the time you have, select the questions that work within your schedule for training. Since we are utilizing the "pair and share" method, you should provide the participants with 2 minutes each to discuss their answers (let them know when to switch to keep them on time). Then have those who want to share their answers with the whole group a chance to do so (select 2 or 3 people to share - do not force participation). This can take up to 5 minutes. In total the pair and share technique for each question will take approximately 10 minutes. If you do not use the pair and share, allow 5-7 minutes for individuals to respond to the who group.

Managing Unique Relationships General Questions

The following questions are based on the Managing Unique Relationships video:

1. How do you approach establishing communication with someone you lead, especially in a unique relationship (e.g., a friend or someone more experienced)? How do you ensure that this initial conversation sets the tone for fairness and transparency moving forward? What strategies do you use to avoid favoritism or bias when leading someone you already know well or someone with tenure?
2. How do you balance maintaining professionalism while acknowledging the unique aspects of a relationship, both inside and outside of work? How do you ensure that personal relationships do not cloud your professional judgment when making decisions? In what ways do you manage potential conflicts that arise from the overlap of personal and professional boundaries?
3. When conflicts or issues arise, how do you ensure you understand the root cause before taking action, especially in relationships where trust may already be established? How do you balance seeking to understand the issue with the need to provide prompt feedback or resolution? How do you ensure your own emotions do not interfere with the process of managing conflicts or providing feedback?
4. How do you clarify expectations and set mutually agreed-upon goals with someone you lead, particularly when there are unique relational dynamics at play? What methods do you use to ensure that expectations are communicated clearly, understood, and respected on both sides? How do you hold people accountable to these expectations while maintaining a positive and respectful relationship?

5. How do you create a foundation of respect and open communication in unique leadership relationships, while also maintaining clear boundaries? How do you honor past contributions or experiences of someone you lead while focusing on future collaboration and growth? In what ways do you collaborate on goal setting to ensure both parties' values and interests are aligned?

Additional Activity on Managing Unique Relationships:

1. Self-Assessment: Begin the workshop by providing participants with the Managing Unique Relationships Self-Assessment questionnaire (*provided at the end of this facilitation guide*). Encourage them to reflect on their current level of Managing Unique Relationships. Ask participants to rate their effectiveness in key areas such as communication in unique relationships, managing up, and leading friends at work.
2. Group Discussion: Facilitate a group discussion where participants share their self-assessment results and insights. Encourage open dialogue about common challenges and best practices for dealing with unique relationships in leadership. Guide participants to identify common themes and patterns in addressing these unique relationship dynamics both personally and professionally.

The Key to "Managing Up" Questions

The following questions are based on the Keys to "Managing Up" Article:

1. In your opinion, is it important to learn to manage up? Why or why not? Is it your responsibility to learn how to adjust your communication style to align with the preferred methods of senior leaders or is it the senior leader's responsibility? If it is your responsibility. how do you determine the most effective way to present information (e.g., email, in-person, formal reports)? How do you balance clear communication with respecting their time constraints?
2. How do you identify and understand the key priorities and goals of the senior leaders you report to? What steps do you take to stay updated on shifts in those priorities over time? How do you ensure that your work aligns with those priorities to support the broader organizational mission?
3. How do you ensure you're providing the right amount of proactive information to senior leaders without overwhelming them? What strategies do you use to keep senior leaders informed about both successes and challenges in your work? How do you solicit feedback on your communication with senior leaders and adjust your approach accordingly?
4. How do you strategically align your personal and team goals with the overarching organizational objectives set by senior leadership? What process do you use to prioritize tasks that contribute to these broader goals? How do you communicate these priorities effectively to your team to ensure alignment?
5. How do you build credibility with senior leaders through your work performance? What actions do you take to consistently demonstrate reliability and expertise to senior

leaders? How do you respond when things go wrong, and how do you communicate issues to senior leaders without damaging your credibility?

6. How do you demonstrate strategic thinking when presenting solutions to senior leaders? How do you ensure that your proposed solutions align with the long-term goals of the organization? What steps do you take to gather data and perspectives before proposing solutions?

Additional *"Managing Up"* Activity:

Objective: The goal of this activity is to provide leaders with a hands-on experience in "managing up" by understanding senior leaders' perspectives, communicating effectively, and aligning their work with organizational goals. This exercise helps participants reflect on how to enhance relationships with senior leaders while practicing key strategies for effective communication, prioritization, and influence.

Activity Overview:

Step 1: Introduction

The facilitator introduces the concept of managing up, highlighting these four best practices:

a. *Understanding the senior leader's perspective*.
b. *Focusing on effective communication*.
c. *Building strategic alignment*.
d. *Fostering influence and credibility*.

Discuss how managing up enhances both the leader's performance and the broader organizational goals. Reference the *Key to "Managing Up"* resource article.

Step 2: Scenario Role-Play

Participants are divided into small groups of 4-5 people. Each group is assigned a different senior leader profile *(you can find six scenarios at the end of the facilitation guide*), which includes:

- The senior leader's key priorities.
- Their communication preferences (formal/informal, email/in-person, etc.).
- Their time constraints and challenges.
- A set of issues or goals that the team must manage in alignment with the senior leader's objectives.

Task: Each group will role-play as both the leader and the senior leader in a meeting where they must present their key updates, explain challenges, and align on solutions while managing the senior leader's expectations. The role-play should focus on:

- Identifying the senior leader's goals and adjusting communication accordingly.
- Structuring information in a clear, concise manner.
- Addressing any potential challenges and proposing strategic solutions.

Step 3: Debrief and Reflection

After the role-play, the facilitator will lead a group discussion on the following:

- What strategies worked well in aligning your message with the senior leader's goals?
- How did you adjust your communication style to fit the leader's preferences?
- What challenges did you face in prioritizing issues and time management?
- How did you manage potential conflicts or competing priorities?

Leading Friends Questions

The following questions are based on the 8 Best Practices for Leading Friends Article:

1. How do you acknowledge the shift in power dynamics when transitioning from a peer to a leader of friends? What are some specific strategies you use to communicate this shift while preserving the friendship? How do you ensure this conversation doesn't lead to discomfort or strain in the relationship?
2. How do you balance your new responsibilities with maintaining a professional relationship with friends in your team? How do you avoid reverting to "friend mode" in stressful situations or moments of conflict? What steps do you take to maintain your authority without creating unnecessary distance?
3. How do you ensure fairness and consistency when managing friends, especially in decision-making and feedback? What systems do you have in place to ensure that all team members are evaluated by the same standards? How do you prevent any perception of favoritism from impacting team morale?
4. How do you set and maintain boundaries early in the transition to a leadership role over friends? What kind of boundaries do you find most important to establish in the early days of your new leadership role? How do you communicate these boundaries clearly without creating tension in the friendship?
5. How do you manage personal interactions with friends outside of work, particularly in a world connected through social media? How do you maintain appropriate boundaries on social media without causing your friends to feel alienated? How do you ensure that your personal interactions don't affect your professional judgment or the perception of your fairness?
6. How do you avoid engaging in gossip and manage it within your team, especially when friends are involved? How do you steer conversations away from gossip while maintaining an open and approachable demeanor? What are some strategies you use to model appropriate behavior and set a standard for professional dialogue in the team?

Additional *Leading Friends* Activity:

Objective: The goal of this activity is to help participants explore the complexities of leading friends, reflect on the importance of setting boundaries, and develop practical strategies for balancing personal and professional relationships in the workplace. Through guided reflection and group discussion, participants will create a visual representation of the

dynamics between personal and professional interactions, identifying challenges and solutions.

Step 1: Introduction

The facilitator introduces the concept of leading friends and outlines the **Eight Best Practices** (from the *Eight Best Practices for Leading Friends* resource article). The facilitator highlights the importance of balancing personal relationships with professional responsibilities and discusses key concepts such as setting boundaries, managing fairness, and handling emotional dynamics.

The facilitator explains that the upcoming activity will allow participants to explore their own experiences and challenges in leading friends and to develop solutions through creative mapping.

Step 2: Boundaries and Balance Map Creation

Participants work individually or in pairs to create a **Boundaries and Balance Map** that visually represents the tension between personal and professional aspects when leading friends. They will identify specific areas where these relationships may be challenged and where boundaries are critical.

Instructions for Participants:

a. **Divide the Poster/Sheet into Two Sections:**
   On one side, write "Personal" and on the other, write "Professional."
b. **Identify Key Friendship Dynamics:**
   On the **Personal** side, write down elements of your friendship with certain colleagues (e.g., trust, history, shared experiences). Use markers and sticky notes to note things like social outings, personal conversations, or shared values outside work.
c. **Identify Leadership Dynamics:**
   On the **Professional** side, list the leadership responsibilities and challenges you face when managing the same friends. Include things like managing performance, delivering feedback, making tough decisions, and setting expectations.
d. **Pinpoint Tensions and Challenges:**
   Draw arrows between the two sides to highlight areas where personal and professional roles overlap or conflict (e.g., “socializing after work” vs. “maintaining authority in meetings”). Mark these overlaps as potential areas where boundaries might blur.
e. **Write Boundaries and Solutions:**
   On sticky notes, add specific **boundaries** or **solutions** you can implement to manage these overlaps. For example, "Refrain from discussing work performance during personal time" or "Ensure team lunches are inclusive of all members, not just close friends." Attach these solutions where the overlaps occur.
f. **Include Emotional Dynamics:**
   On the map, write down any **emotions** or potential reactions—both yours and your friends'—that may arise in challenging situations, like delivering tough feedback or

making decisions that impact your friend negatively. Think about how to manage these emotions.

Step 3: Group Discussion and Sharing

Once participants have completed their maps, the facilitator leads a group discussion. Participants are invited to share key insights from their maps. Focus questions might include:

- What were some of the key areas where personal and professional roles overlap for you?
- How did you decide which boundaries to set? Were there any that surprised you?
- What emotions do you anticipate when making tough decisions, and how will you manage them?

Step 4: Reflection and Action Planning

Participants are asked to take a few minutes to reflect individually and write down one concrete action they will take based on the Boundaries and Balance Map activity. This could involve initiating a boundary-setting conversation with a friend, ensuring more consistent and fair treatment across the team, or seeking out a mentor to help navigate emotional complexities. Participants then briefly share their planned action steps with the group to encourage accountability and support.

General Managing Unique Relationships Self Assessment

Instructions: Please rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 indicates "Strongly Disagree" and 5 indicates "Strongly Agree."

1. I initiate open communication early when managing unique relationships (e.g., friends or tenured employees).

1 2 3 4 5

2. I consistently treat all team members fairly, regardless of personal relationships.

1 2 3 4 5

3. I avoid showing favoritism, even with friends or long-term colleagues.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I am transparent in my communication with team members, particularly in unique relationships.

1 2 3 4 5

5. I am mindful of balancing personal and professional boundaries with individuals I manage.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I address conflicts or issues promptly with all team members, even those with whom I have a close relationship.

1 2 3 4 5

7. I lead by example in terms of work ethic and work-life balance, regardless of my personal connection to the team member.

1 2 3 4 5

8. I provide growth opportunities to all employees fairly, including those with whom I have close relationships.

1 2 3 4 5

9. I celebrate successes consistently, without showing favoritism.

1 2 3 4 5

10. I listen carefully to the needs and wants of all employees, even those I am personally close to.

1 2 3 4 5

11. I actively seek to understand the root cause of issues before taking action, particularly in unique relationships.

1 2 3 4 5

12. I manage my emotions well when leading individuals with whom I have a close relationship.

1 2 3 4 5

13. I reestablish clear expectations regularly, especially in unique leadership relationships.

1 2 3 4 5

14. I hold all employees accountable to mutually agreed-upon goals, regardless of our personal relationship.

1 2 3 4 5

15. I seek outside opinions or help when needed to better manage unique relationships.

1 2 3 4 5

16. I actively work to maintain a clear slate and focus on how to move forward after conflicts or challenges.

1 2 3 4 5

17. I build a foundation of respect with all team members, including those with whom I have a close personal connection.

1 2 3 4 5

18. I engage in open, caring communication, even when managing former peers or friends.

1 2 3 4 5

19. I collaborate on setting goals and identifying shared values, regardless of my personal connection to the employee.

1 2 3 4 5

20. I provide regular feedback and set time for ongoing discussions with team members, even in unique relationships.

1 2 3 4 5

Scoring: Calculate your total score by adding up the ratings for each statement. A higher score indicates stronger Managing Unique Relationship skills and habits.

Total Score: _____

Interpretation:

- **80-100**: **Highly Effective at Managing Unique Relationships**
  You have a strong ability to navigate unique relationships, demonstrating fairness, transparency, and professionalism. You balance personal connections with leadership responsibilities, fostering a healthy and productive work environment.
- **60-79**: **You Are Effective, With Opportunities for Growth**
  You manage unique relationships well, but there may be areas where greater attention to boundaries, fairness, or communication could improve your leadership. Reflect on areas where your score was lower and focus on enhancing your skills.
- **40-59**: **Improvement Needed In Managing Unique Relationships**
  You may find it challenging to consistently manage unique relationships in a fair and transparent way. Consider focusing on setting clear boundaries, managing emotions, and ensuring that all team members feel equally supported.
- **20-39**: **Significant Development Needed to Help Lead in Unique Situations**
  You likely struggle to manage unique relationships effectively, which could lead to bias, favoritism, or conflicts within your team. It may be helpful to seek guidance or training on managing professional relationships and maintaining fairness across all team dynamics.

Scenario 1: Competing Department Priorities and Cross-Functional Tensions

You are the head of a marketing team, and your senior leader, the Chief Marketing Officer (CMO), has set an urgent priority on a new product launch for the next quarter. This initiative has come from the CEO as part of a strategic push to enter a competitive market. However, your marketing team is already deeply engaged in a major rebranding initiative that was greenlit and heavily invested in by the same CMO just a few months ago. Internal stakeholders in the rebranding effort—especially the Sales and Product teams—are already frustrated with delays, and pausing it now could cause significant backlash.

Additionally, your team is overstretched. You've lost two key staff members recently, and recruiting replacements has been slow. If you shift all your focus to the product launch, the rebranding will likely face major delays, leading to discontent within the organization and potentially damaging customer perception. The CMO expects both projects to be successful but has not provided additional resources or clear guidance on how to prioritize the workload.

Task:
Prepare for a one-on-one meeting with the CMO to present a clear analysis of the situation. Your goal is to balance competing priorities without derailing either project. Highlight the resource constraints, the internal tensions, and the potential consequences of delaying the rebranding effort. Propose potential solutions such as temporary external support, reallocating internal resources, or adjusting project timelines. Be prepared to manage the CMO's expectations, offer data-driven insights, and negotiate a feasible path forward while preserving relationships across departments.

Scenario 2: Tight Deadlines, Limited Resources, and Stakeholder Pressure

You are the head of the IT department, reporting to the Chief Technology Officer (CTO). The CTO has emphasized that a company-wide software upgrade must be completed within three months, due to a vendor contract deadline and compliance concerns raised by the legal department. The upgrade will modernize outdated systems and has been hailed by senior leadership as critical to operational efficiency.

However, your department is severely understaffed due to recent turnover, and existing team members are already working overtime to handle urgent technical issues related to cybersecurity incidents. Meanwhile, several department heads have raised concerns about the upgrade disrupting day-to-day operations, especially in departments reliant on legacy systems. The pressure is mounting, with stakeholders across the company worried about how the IT changes will impact their workflows, and the CTO is pushing for swift progress without delays.

Task:
Prepare a strategic proposal for your upcoming meeting with the CTO. Outline the challenges

your team is facing, from limited manpower to potential operational disruptions during the upgrade. Be ready to propose alternative strategies, such as extending the timeline, outsourcing some of the work to an external partner, or focusing the initial rollout on high-priority systems. You'll need to convey the risks of proceeding without adequate resources and offer a solution that balances urgency with practical constraints, all while managing the CTO's expectations for the project's success.

Scenario 3: Shifting Organizational Goals and a Morale Crisis

You are the head of the Sales Department, and for the past six months, your team has been working under clear marching orders from the Chief Sales Officer (CSO) to develop a strategic plan focused on expanding into new, international markets. This expansion strategy has been a key initiative, with significant resources allocated, and your team has already made considerable progress. Contracts are being negotiated, new market research has been completed, and sales targets are being set.

Suddenly, during a recent executive meeting, the CEO announced a shift in priorities due to market instability and pressure from shareholders to improve short-term profits. The focus has now shifted from expansion to cost-cutting measures and consolidating existing customer relationships. This pivot has left your team frustrated, demoralized, and unclear about the future of the expansion plan. You've already invested time, resources, and energy, and there is confusion about whether to abandon the initiative or repurpose the efforts.

Task:
Prepare for a difficult conversation with the CSO, where you'll need to address the team's concerns, the progress that's already been made on the expansion strategy, and how to realign your team's efforts with the new corporate priorities. You'll need to propose ways to salvage parts of the work that's been done, such as leveraging market research for future projects or maintaining key relationships in potential growth areas. Be ready to negotiate for resources to help your team manage the pivot without losing motivation and ensure their hard work doesn't go to waste.

Scenario 4: Cross-Departmental Misalignment and Bottlenecks

You lead the Customer Service Department, and you report to the Vice President of Operations (VP). Recently, customer satisfaction scores have plummeted, with negative reviews highlighting slow response times and unresolved issues. In response, the VP has made improving these scores a top priority and has tasked your team with rolling out several initiatives to address the problems, such as new training programs and a revamped customer service portal.

However, much of the initiative's success relies on support from the Operations and IT departments, which have been slow to implement the necessary back-end changes to the

customer service systems. The Operations team, led by a colleague, is facing its own internal challenges, including staffing shortages and a backlog of critical projects. The VP is pressing you for results, but without cross-departmental alignment, your team is struggling to deliver the expected improvements, and the blame is starting to shift toward you.

Task:
Prepare for a high-stakes meeting with the VP. You'll need to explain the roadblocks caused by the misalignment between departments and propose solutions for getting buy-in from the Operations and IT teams. Be prepared to suggest ways to escalate these challenges, such as facilitating cross-departmental collaboration or proposing a joint task force. Focus on how to get these departments back on track without creating friction and ensure that you still meet the VP's goals for customer satisfaction improvements.

Scenario 5: Budget Cuts Threatening a Strategic Project

You are the head of the Research & Development (R&D) team, working on an innovative long-term project to develop a new product line. The project has been a cornerstone of the company's future strategy, and your senior leader, the Chief Innovation Officer (CIO), has been its key champion. Recently, the company announced significant budget cuts in response to declining quarterly profits. These cuts are directly impacting your project, reducing your funding by 30%.

The budget reduction will likely delay the project's key milestones and force you to scale back critical elements, such as testing and prototyping. Your team is concerned about losing momentum, and some members are starting to question whether the project will be successful at all. Meanwhile, the CIO expects you to deliver the innovation on time and within the new budget constraints, even though the original scope of work was far more ambitious.

Task:
Prepare for a critical conversation with the CIO, where you'll need to present the impact of the budget cuts and propose a revised project plan. You'll need to explore alternatives, such as focusing on high-impact areas, extending timelines, or finding cost-effective solutions. It's crucial to manage the CIO's expectations while protecting the integrity of the project. Be ready to discuss the long-term implications for the company's innovation strategy and secure support to avoid further cuts or delays.

Scenario 6: Limited Availability of Senior Leaders and Project Delays

You are leading a cross-functional team responsible for a major organizational change initiative that will streamline operations and save the company millions over the next few years. However, the project requires frequent input and approval from the Chief Operating Officer (COO), who is your direct senior leader. The COO, however, has an extremely demanding schedule, spending much of their time traveling or in high-level meetings with

other executives. This limited availability is causing delays in key decisions, and your team is starting to fall behind on critical milestones.

Additionally, other departments, such as Finance and HR, are heavily invested in the project's success, and they're beginning to express concerns about the delays. The COO has made it clear that they expect the project to be delivered on time, but their unavailability is becoming a significant barrier to success.

Task:
Prepare for a meeting with the COO where you'll need to address the delays caused by their limited availability. You'll need to propose a more structured communication process, such as regular, brief check-ins or assigning a proxy decision-maker when the COO is unavailable. Focus on maintaining momentum while respecting the COO's time constraints and ensuring that other departments remain confident in the project's trajectory.